historical issue is also alive in Sino–Japanese relations, giving China sufficient reason to resent India's closeness to Japan in addition to the perception of a nascent containment strategy being jointly developed by Tokyo and Delhi with regard to Beijing.

China is most frequently cited as the reason behind the India–Japan post–Cold War rapprochement.[12] China's large and growing military budget, its increasing assertiveness in land-based and maritime territorial disputes, and its grand strategy of containing potential rivals by cultivating client states such as Pakistan and North Korea have ostensibly given India and Japan sufficient reason to build a strategic partnership. However, short of a full-fledged alliance similar to the US–Japan alliance, it is unclear how India and Japan can cooperate to contain a rising China. Neither Delhi nor Tokyo has the appetite or the resources to take on Beijing either separately or together in a potentially militarised conflict in the Indo-Pacific region. There are few scenarios short of all-out continental war that might bring India or Japan to the military aid of the other in a conflict against China. Both capitals are aware of this commitment problem and are at pains to develop at least a rhetorical challenge to China without in fact antagonising Beijing. Thus, there is little an India–Japan partnership can do to deter Chinese expansion and potential aggression in the region.

Despite this drawback, Japan has bet big on India primarily due to an additional factor: the increasing unreliability of US alliance commitments in Asia. Washington's declining defence budget, half-hearted implementation of the Asian rebalance, and apparent lack of resolve in the face of Russian obduracy in cases such as the Crimea and the Syrian civil war had already planted doubts in the minds of Japanese policymakers. President Donald Trump's isolationist tendencies and stated policy positions that would require Japan to shoulder a greater financial